





adjust the margins thereafter – paying more attention in the latter case to absolute proportion than to convenient units of measurement. When space is measured purely in points, the temptation to rearrange it into even picas is miraculously lessened.

Improvisations and Adjustments

8.8.3 *Keep the page design supple enough to provide a livable home for the text.*

Architects build perfectly proportioned kitchens, living rooms and bedrooms in which their clients will make, among other things, a mess. Typographers likewise build perfectly proportioned pages, then distort them on demand. The text takes precedence over the purity of the design, and the typographic texture of the text takes precedence over the absolute proportions of the individual page.

If, for instance, three lines remain at the end of a chapter, looking forlorn on a page of their own, the design must flex to accommodate them. The obvious choices are: (1) running two of the previous spreads a line long (that is, adding one line to the depth of two pairs of facing pages), which will leave the final page one line short; (2) running half a dozen of the previous spreads a line short, thereby bumping a dozen lines along to the final page; or (3) reportioning some non-textual element – perhaps an illustration or the sinkage, if any, at the head of the chapter.

Spacious chapter heads stand out in a book, as they are meant to. Repportioning the sinkage is therefore a poor option unless all chapter heads can be reportioned to match. And running six spreads short is, on the face of it, clearly a greater evil than running two spreads long.

If there are only a few pages to the document, the whole thing can, and probably should, be redesigned to fit the text. But in a book of many pages, widow lines, orphaned subheads, and the runt ends of chapters or sections are certain to require reportioning some spreads. A rigid design that demands an invariant page depth is therefore inappropriate for a work of any length. Altering the leading on short pages to preserve a standard depth (vertical justification, it is sometimes called) is not a solution. Neither is stuffing extra space between the paragraphs. These antics destroy the fabric of the text and thus strike at the heart of the book.

THE STATE OF THE ART

The state of the art has more by far to do with the knowledge and skill of its practitioners than with the subtleties of their tools, but tools can constrain that skill or set it free. The limitations of the tools are therefore also of some interest. They are of special interest now, because they are subject to rapid change.

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9.1 THE HUNDRED-THOUSAND CHARACTER ALPHABET

It is often said that the Latin alphabet consists of 26 letters, the Greek of 24 and the Arabic of 28. If you confine yourself to one case only, a narrow historical window and the dialect in power, this assertion can hold true. If you include both caps and lower case, accented letters and a global set of consonants and vowels – á à â ã ä å æ ç è é ê ë ì í î ï ð ñ ò ó ô õ ö ø ù ú û ü ý ÿ ž – and all the rest – the Latin alphabet is not 26 letters long after all; it is closer to 600 and able to increase at any time. The alphabet that classicists now use for classical Greek, with its long parade of vowels and diacritics – á â ã ä å æ ç è é ê ë ì í î ï ð ñ ò ó ô õ ö ø ù ú û ü ý ÿ ž – is modest by comparison: fewer than 300 glyphs altogether.

To the 600-character globalized Latin alphabet, mathematicians, grammarians, chemists and even typographers are prone to make additions: arabic numerals, punctuation, technical symbols, letters borrowed from Hebrew, Greek and Cyrillic, and, where the letterforms require or invite them, a few typographic ligatures and alternates as well. There is no hope at this stage of counting the number of sorts or glyphs precisely, but the total is clearly over a thousand.

At the end of the eighteenth century, an English-speaking hand compositor's standard lower case had 54 compartments, holding roman or italic *a* to *z*, arabic numerals, basic ligatures, spaces and punctuation. The upper case had another 98, containing caps and alphabets. That total, 98 + 54 = 152, is the English-speaking hand compositor's minimum basic allotment. When more sorts are required, as they very often are, supplementary cases are used. Two pair give 304 compartments; three pair give 456; four pair give 608. This has been the ordinary typographic ballpark for some time. How Gutenberg's cases were arranged we do not know, but we know how big they were. He used not 26

Printing enthusiasts sometimes speak of the lay of the case as if it were universal law - but the lay of the case is as localized as the lay of the land. Hand compositors often set not from paired but from single cases. These have been reduced to as few as 89 compartments but sometimes contain 400 or more.

